He looks at me, says nothing and slowly shakes his head as if he simply can't believe this insignificant youngster from Pretoria has dared speak to him. I feel six inches tall, blush and walk away.

Glenn McGrath has witnessed the exchange; he follows me into the corridor and taps me on the shoulder. 'Don't worry about him,' he says. 'He's always grumpy. You're doing well. Keep going.'

In 20 seconds, the great fast bowler makes me feel fully five feet ten-and-a-half inches again and shows why he is revered as one of the sport's true gentlemen, respected wherever the game is played.

Encouraged, I score 61 in our first innings before falling LBW to the selfsame McGrath, even though I reckon the ball struck me outside the line. We fight hard, as usual, but subside to McGrath and Warne in the second innings, lose at the MCG and are then defeated in the third Test at Sydney. Australia win the series 2–0.

Nobody likes losing but I feel positive about my performance. Then Haroon Lorgat, convener of selectors, calls me aside and tells me they have decided to leave me out of the squad for the triangular ODI series with Australia and Sri Lanka. I am distraught. I want to stay with the team but, instead, I must fly home.

2006

The best response to being dropped is to say nothing and score loads of runs. I find some form while playing for the Titans in the domestic T20 series and, when the Proteas arrive home in mid-February, I am recalled to the side for the home leg of the series against Australia: a T20 international, five one-day internationals and three Tests.

We win the T20 by two runs and take a 2–0 lead in the ODI series, but are then pegged back by the Australians and stand level at 2–2 when we head to the fifth and deciding ODI in Johannesburg. It is 12 March 2006, and a full house at the Bullring witnesses maybe the most